Teaching and Assessing EIL in Local Contexts Around the World



Sandra Lee McKay
and James Dean Brown

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ROUTLEDGE

TEACHING AND ASSESSING EIL IN LOCAL CONTEXTS AROUND THE WORLD

English today is a global language and at the same time is embedded in a great variety of social contexts, resulting in linguistic and pedagogical variation. Taking a new look at the pedagogy of teaching and assessing English as an international language (EIL), this text highlights overarching principles and provides specific strategies for responding to questions and challenges posed by the changing demographics of English language learners and users around the world.

Teaching and Assessing EIL in Local Contexts Around the World

- introduces an original, coherent framework in which needs analysis, pedagogical principles, and assessment are integrated;
- describes variables that influence effective teaching and assessment and the characteristics of various EIL teachers and learners;
- emphasizes that pedagogical and assessment decisions need to be based on the learning and teaching needs of each specific EIL context;
- includes specific principles and strategies for teaching and assessing grammar, oral language, and literacy skills in EIL classrooms;
- provides strategies for integrating computer-mediated language into EIL classrooms in ways that promote cross-cultural awareness, language development, and individualized learning.

Timely, accessible, and practical, this text for graduate and pre- and in-service courses on language teaching and assessment is at the forefront in providing valuable information and guidance for enabling principled and context-sensitive praxis in EIL classrooms worldwide.

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In Fond Memory of Gerry McKay from his loving wife and his friend, JD

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INTRODUCTION

This book is based on two assumptions: first, because of the large and growing number of L2 speakers of English around the globe, English is an international language; and second, because of the diversity of English learning contexts today, all teaching and assessing of English must be based on locally defined goals and standards. Hence, we argue for *locally defined English as an international (EIL) teaching and assessment* informed by goals and standards that are in keeping with the local teaching context.

The book is addressed to all educators and administrators who share the goal of developing an English language teaching approach that provides learners with realistic goals that meet their local and global objectives in learning English. Before we provide an overview of the book, it is helpful to clarify what we mean by locally defined EIL teaching and assessment. In order to do this, we must first address the issue of Standard English since it is this concept that has historically driven much of English language teaching.

The Native Speaker Standard

The majority of English teaching today is based on the assumption that the goal of learners is to acquire Standard English based on the language spoken by native speakers of English; but what exactly is this so-called *native speaker standard* in English? In order to understand this phrase, we need to understand what a *native speaker* is and what a *standard* is. Unfortunately, both terms have a great variety of meanings and nuances.

Native Speaker

According to Davies (2004), a *native speaker* (NS) can be one of several things, including the following: NSs acquire their L1 in childhood; have intuitions about

their idiolectal grammar and about the features of standard English grammar that differ from their idiolectal grammar; display a wide range communicative competence; have a unique capacity to spontaneously produce fluent discourse, to write creatively, and to interpret and translate into English (condensed from Davies, 2004, p. 435). Davies has captured something valuable in the features he has listed. However, even he admits that "a definition of the native speaker is elusive" (Davies, 2004, p. 431).

What most lay people and even many teachers mean by a NS is not directly associated with the features Davies (2004) listed. Instead, the NS is described as a person who speaks *good English*, or *grammatical*, *correct*, *educated*, or *proper* English. Others more interested in power relationships, might think of a NS as using one of the politically, socially, culturally, or even militarily dominant dialects of English.

Another way to think about native speakers is to ask which people serve as a model of the native speaker. Is there a single individual who in your mind represents the quintessential native speaker? The Queen of England? Tony Blair? Barbara Walters? Dan Rather? No, not really, since each one has a unique ideolect. In most cases, what people are describing when they talk about a native speaker or the native speaker model is not a real person at all or even a group of people, but rather an *idealized native speaker* (Leung, Harris, & Rampton, 1997). The idealized native speaker is a construct, not a real person.

Standard

A *standard* can be one of several things. First, a standard can be a norm or an average, which is *about people* and implies that the standard is the norm or average of the English spoken by people, probably native speakers. However, it is difficult to determine what that norm or average would actually be across all native speakers, across all Englishes, across all dialects, and especially across all educational levels. Second, a standard can also be seen quite differently as a certain criterion, benchmark, or acceptable/passing level of English, which is *about English* itself, that is, the system of English that all native speakers learn, with varying degrees of success. Everyone, from the Queen of England to her stable boy and from Dan Rather to the youngest American school child, learns more or less the same system—Standard English. The system is controlled and passed on by grammarians, lexicographers, English teachers, and parents everywhere, and importantly, the system is largely the same across Englishes all over the world. It is the latter sense of standard that we support in this book. However, in many EIL classrooms the idealized native speaker standard is what is promoted. The question is: Is this an attainable goal?

Setting Realistic Learning Goals

We maintain that the idealized native speaker standard is impossible for most learners around the world to achieve. As we argue at greater length in Chapter

Three, the goal of attaining near-native speaker proficiency and fluency, given the difficulty of defining such a construct, is a wonderful dream, but one that is unattainable in the six years of English instruction that most students around the world get. In this way, language classes frequently set up a model that students cannot achieve and then, the English curriculum, teachers, or students are blamed for that failure.

We propose two solutions to this pervasive problem: abandon the idealized native speaker standard in favor of a global English standard; and shift to intelligibility goals that are in fact achievable.

A Global English Standard

One solution for all of the problems raised by the idealized native speaker standard is to abandon that notion altogether and use instead the construct of a *Global English Standard* (GES). The idea of a GES would be that it:

- Is based on the second definition of standard discussed above which focuses on the system of English, rather than on some idealized native speaker.
- Recognizes that there is a system of English that is taught across the globe to native speakers (regardless of which English or dialect they speak, or their social standing or educational level) and to so-called non-native speakers[1] alike.
- Emphasizes the idea that capital-G English Grammar (especially the written grammar) is fairly homogeneous across all Englishes, dialects, and learners.
- Acknowledges the importance of a center or common system around the world for English that will maximize effective communication—especially in certain formal genres of written English.
- Sidesteps the sense (implicit in the idealized native speaker standard) that native speakers own English and its standard, instead promoting the idea that GES, by definition, is owned by all speakers of English.
- Can easily coexist with various Englishes and dialects around the world, whenever and wherever it is needed.

The Intelligibility Principle

Our second solution is to provide goals that are in fact achievable, which from an EIL perspective means narrowing the target to whatever locally defined English most students actually need and can attain. Instead of comparing students' progress to an ideal native speaker standard that they will fail to attain, we believe it is pedagogically more realistic and fairer in EIL classrooms to apply the intelligibility principle. What do we meant by this? In Chapter Five, we argue that, the *nativeness principle*, which ". . . holds that it is both possible and desirable to achieve native-like pronunciation in a foreign language," is unreasonable. In

contrast, in EIL settings, it makes much more sense to implement the *intelligibility principle*, which ". . . holds that learners simply need to be understandable" (Levis, 2005, p. 370 for both quotes). While applying the nativeness principle sets an impossible goal, shifting to the intelligibility principle and locally defined EIL targets, sets goals and standards that are relevant, useful, and attainable.

Locally Defined EIL

The next issue we need to address is what the phrase *locally defined EIL* means. As we see it, this phrase has two parts, *EIL* and *locally defined*.

EIL

Since this book is all about teaching and assessing locally defined *EIL*, we first need to clarify just what we mean by EIL. We see EIL pedagogy as instruction that recognizes that English is an international language with wide geographical distribution and is the most studied second language in the world. Because of its widespread use and geographical distribution, it is frequently used in cross-cultural exchanges. This situation leads to particular features of English that have clear implications for teaching and assessing EIL. These features include the following.

1. Present-day English, especially oral English, has great variation on the phonological, structural, lexical, pragmatic, and discourse levels. In some contexts, these variations are considered standard in the geographical region in which they exist. This is why we started this introduction by questioning the appropriateness of the so-called native speaker standard.
2. In many teaching and learning contexts, attaining so-called native-like proficiency is not the goal of English learners. Rather, learners desire to be intelligible speakers of English, retaining features of their own phonological, lexical, structural, pragmatic, and discourse norms.
3. Because English is a required foreign language in many countries, L2 speakers of English are frequently teaching English. This has resulted in a critical debate as to the role of native speakers as teachers of English. In this book, we argue that ideal teachers of English can be either first- or second-language speakers of English.
4. Currently, English proficiency is often a prerequisite for entry to prestigious educational institutions and good-paying jobs. Because of this, the learning of English is frequently associated with educational and economic mobility.
5. Today English is a language embedded in many cultures and no longer the language of only countries where it is the sole official language, such as Britain and the United States. Because of this, the cultural basis for teaching English is far more complex than teaching a language which is almost exclusively spoken in just one country.

6. The majority of exchanges in English today occur between L2 and L2 speakers. In such exchanges, breakdowns in communication can occur due to a lack of proficiency on the part of the speakers. Speakers of English thus need to learn strategies for repairing breakdowns in communication.

In defining EIL classrooms, it is also necessary to distinguish the concept of *English as an international language* (EIL) from *World Englishes* (WE) and *English as a lingua franca* (ELF). One of the main goals of those who investigate World Englishes is to document the variation that exists in the use of English in particular areas of the world. Whereas those who adhere to an EIL perspective clearly respect and draw on the work of WE scholars, the EIL perspective is much broader, dealing with issues such as the cultural basis of teaching English, the role of L2 speakers of English as teachers, and the economic and educational power of English.

In contrast, Firth's (1996) seminal definition of ELF was "a 'contact language' between persons who share neither a common native tongue nor a common (national) culture, and for whom English is the chosen *foreign* language of communication" [emphasis in original] (p. 240). Frequently, the goal of ELF research is to document the features of exchanges that occur between L2 speakers of English. Again, while those who support an EIL perspective respect and refer to the work being done in this area, ELF does not address many of the issues enumerated above, such as the cultural basis of English teaching and the educational and economic consequences of learning English.

Locally Defined EIL

As we will discuss at greater length in Chapter Three and elsewhere, *locally defined* EIL (proposed in Brown, 2012) has certain key characteristics in addition to those described above. Specifically, *locally defined EIL*:

- Stresses that local needs for English including its international uses should be carefully considered and are paramount in setting pedagogical goals.
- Builds on a thorough needs analysis of the use of EIL (including the language and context) in a particular local English teaching/learning setting.
- Centers curriculum choices on local needs for English when considering all aspects of curriculum including content, resources, units of analysis, objectives, teaching strategies, assessment, and so forth.
- Is found and most needed in locations where English is not the native tongue, especially in Outer and Expanding Circle English contexts.
- Motivates students to learn because it is based on local language and materials that are directly relevant to their lives.
- Delimits EIL learning goals to realistic and attainable proportions and thereby reduces the amount of material teachers must cover as well as what students must learn to be successful.

In sum, we believe that the goal of attaining a native speaker standard is an unfortunate and unattainable goal in English learning, one that has driven ELT pedagogy for many years. We maintain that it is necessary today, given the international status of English, to narrow that goal to helping learners achieve locally defined, relevant learning goals.

This Book

The purpose of this book is to explore what locally defined EIL goals suggest for teaching and assessing EIL wherever it may be taught. To that general end, each chapter includes an introduction that lists some of the misconceptions that teachers have about the issues involved, key definitions, explanations of relevant applications to teaching, ideas for assessment, a summary, key principles, discussion questions, application tasks, and references.

Overall, the book includes this introduction and seven chapters. The first three chapters provide relevant background: Chapter One on the social and educational context of EIL classrooms; Chapter Two about the roles of teachers and learners, and EIL classroom interactions; and Chapter Three on the issues involved in doing needs assessment in locally defined EIL contexts. The next three chapters then address the issues involved in teaching and assessing specific aspects of locally defined EIL, including teaching and assessing *grammar* (Chapter Four), *oracy* (Chapter Five), and *literacy* (Chapter Six). The book ends with Chapter Seven, which discusses ways to integrate technology into locally defined EIL teaching and assessment. Let's consider each chapter in more detail.

Chapter One examines the social and educational context of EIL classrooms. Many of the factors that language teachers need to consider in making pedagogical decisions relate to the social and institutional context where they teach. We address these factors with specific focus on the current status of English around the world; common features of English varieties; prevalent attitudes toward such varieties including the issue of standards; as well as widespread trends in English education around the world.

Chapter Two considers the roles of teachers, learners, and classroom interaction in EIL. A large proportion of EIL classes are in public schools at the primary and secondary levels. We discuss issues involved in EIL classroom interaction, and also challenge three common misconceptions about English classes in such situations: (a) local bilingual teachers of English are not as effective as native speakers of English; (b) students in English classes have little motivation to study English; and (c) English-only is the most effective approach for teaching EIL.

Chapter Three addresses key aspects of EIL students' English needs by arguing for *needs assessment* (NA) (that is, gathering information about what the learners and teachers require for learning to succeed). To that end, we examine four misconceptions about what English students need: (a) high levels of fluency and proficiency in English are attainable in six years; (b) all high school students are preparing for

university entrance examinations; (c) NA is a formal set of procedures that experts use; and (d) students' needs are the language forms they need to learn.

Chapter Four focuses on the issues involved in teaching and assessing *grammar* including the complexity of teaching and assessing grammar in EIL situations and the diversity of forms currently used in English. We also examine how this diversity is a factor based on geographical region, the characteristics of the users (e.g., their educational and economic background), and the uses to which English is put (i.e., spoken versus written English). We end by considering what this diversity means for teaching and assessing grammar in EIL classrooms.

Chapter Five examines the teaching and assessing of *oracy* in EIL contexts. Beginning with an exploration of what oracy means, we then examine the concepts of traditionally defined fluency and EIL fluency. We also address the importance of intelligibility in EIL, advocate a broader view of what speaker-listener intelligibility means, and examine pronunciation features that are likely to interfere with intelligibility. We then turn to discussions of the notion of *scope of proficiency* and what we call the 12 keys to teaching oracy in EIL classrooms.

Chapter Six explores the teaching and assessing of *literacy* in EIL contexts. We particularly emphasize the ways that culturally influenced discourse patterns and content schema relate to reading and writing processes. Our primary focus is on the cultural aspect of literacy because EIL texts are often embedded in various cultural contexts. We also explore what incorporating cultural aspects into literacy implies for teaching and assessing literacy in EIL classrooms.

Chapter Seven examines the issues involved in integrating technology into EIL classrooms by showing ways that computers can be used to enhance the development of language skills through cross-cultural exchanges and awareness. We discuss at length ways that corpora, software, and websites can be used in EIL classrooms. We also address low-technology contexts in which physical and human constraints may hinder the use of technology in teaching EIL and suggest specific ways these constraints can be dealt with.

Note

1. We need to state up front that we will avoid using the term *non-native* for English speakers throughout this book wherever possible (except where material we are quoting uses it, or where we are expanding on such a quote). We do so because *non-native* characterizes such people negatively, as though they are lacking something that native speakers have. We much prefer referring to such people as *bilingual speakers of English*, which emphasizes that they have something that most native speakers lack.

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1

THE SOCIAL AND EDUCATIONAL CONTEXT OF EIL CLASSROOMS

Many of the factors that language teachers need to consider in making pedagogical decisions relate to the social and institutional context in which they teach. In terms of the social context, teachers need to consider questions such as the following: Is English widely used in the community where they live? Is English one of the home languages of the students? Does speaking English have social prestige, economic rewards, and educational value within the country? Furthermore, there are institutional factors to consider. Is English a required foreign language? At what age do students start learning English? What goals does the ministry of education have for the learning of English? The purpose of this chapter is to examine such questions in relation to the teaching of English as an international language (EIL). Specifically, we will focus on the following topics:

- The current status of English around the world;
- Typical features of English varieties, popular attitudes toward these varieties, and the issue of standards; and,
- Prevalent trends in English education.

The Current Status of English

Number of Speakers and Geographical Spread

Two salient facts about English that contribute to its being a global language are first, it is widely spoken as a second language; and second, it is spoken in many areas of the world. It is, of course, extremely difficult to determine how many people today speak English. First, one needs to determine what it means to speak a language. Is minimal conversational ability sufficient to be considered

a speaker of the language or must one be able to speak the language fluently? Second, reliable statistics need to be gathered regarding the number of speakers. Such information could be gathered through a rigorous census process, but even if a country has census data that provide such information, how should one determine whether or not an individual speaks English and at what level? With this in mind, let us examine estimates of the current number of native speakers of English in relation to other languages with at least 50 million first-language speakers (www.ethnologue.com/statistics/size, retrieved, January 19, 2014).

Table 1.1 makes clear two important characteristics of English today. First, it is not the most widely spoken language in terms of the number of native speakers. Chinese and Spanish have more first-language speakers. Second, English is by far the most widely geographically distributed language since it is spoken in 101 countries. The only language that comes close to this number is Arabic, which is spoken in only 59 countries.

TABLE 1.1 Languages with at Least 50 Million First-Language Speakers

Rank	*Language*	*Primary Country*	*Total Countries*	*Speakers (millions)*
1	*Chinese [zho]*	*China*	*33*	*1,197*
	Chinese, Gan [gan]	China		20.6
	Chinese, Hakka [hak]	China		30.1
	Chinese, Huizhou [czh]	China		4.60
	Chinese, Jinyu [cjy]	China		45.0
	Chinese, Mandarin [cmn]	China		848
	Chinese, Min Bei [mnp]	China		10.3
	Chinese, Min Dong [cdo]	China		9.12
	Chinese, Min Nan [nan]	China		46.8
	Chinese, Min Zhong [czo]	China		3.10
	Chinese, Pu-Xian [cpx]	China		2.56
	Chinese, Wu [wuu]	China		77.2
	Chinese, Xiang [hsn]	China		36.0
	Chinese, Yue [yue]	China		62.2
2	Spanish [spa]	Spain	31	406
3	English [eng]	United Kingdom	101	335
4	Hindi [hin]	India	4	260
5	*Arabic [ara]*	*Saudi Arabia*	*59*	*223*
	Arabic, Algerian Spoken [arq]	Algeria		28.0
	Arabic, Chadian Spoken [shu]	Chad		1.14

(Continued)

TABLE 1.1 (Continued)

Rank	*Language*	*Primary Country*	*Total Countries*	*Speakers (millions)*
	Arabic, Eastern Egyptian Bedawi Spoken [avl]	Egypt		1.69
	Arabic, Egyptian Spoken [arz]	Egypt		54.0
	Arabic, Gulf Spoken [afb]	Iraq		3.60
	Arabic, Hijazi Spoken [acw]	Saudi Arabia		6.02
	Arabic, Libyan Spoken [ayl]	Libya		4.32
	Arabic, Mesopotamian Spoken [acm]	Iraq		15.1
	Arabic, Moroccan Spoken [ary]	Morocco		21.0
	Arabic, Najdi Spoken [ars]	Saudi Arabia		9.67
	Arabic, North Levantine Spoken [apc]	Syria		14.4
	Arabic, North Mesopotamian Spoken [ayp]	Iraq		6.30
	Arabic, Sa'idi Spoken [aec]	Egypt		19.0
	Arabic, Sanaani Spoken [ayn]	Yemen		7.60
	Arabic, South Levantine Spoken [ajp]	Jordan		6.20
	Arabic, Sudanese Spoken [apd]	Sudan		1.83
	Arabic, Ta'izzi-Adeni Spoken [acq]	Yemen		7.08
	Arabic, Tunisian Spoken [aeb]	Tunisia		9.41
6	Portuguese [por]	Portugal	11	202
7	Bengali [ben]	Bangladesh	4	193
8	Russian [rus]	Russian Federation	16	162
9	Japanese [jpn]	Japan	3	122
10	Javanese [jav]	Indonesia	3	84.3

Note: Table 1.1 lists the largest languages in the world in descending order of first-language speakers. The Primary Country column names the country in which the primary entry for the language is found. The Total Countries column gives the number of countries in the world in which the language is listed either with a full entry or as an immigrant language in the country header. The Speaker column gives the number of first-language speakers in millions. The table rows in italic type represent macrolanguages. . . . In these cases, the Total Countries and speakers columns are totals for all the individual languages listed in the macrolanguage entry as members of the macrolanguage. It includes only those that have a least one million speakers.

If you are curious about where English is widely spoken, there are 60 sovereign states and 28 non-sovereign states where English is an official language. As you would imagine, the majority of these countries are former colonies of the United Kingdom or the United States.

Figure 1.1 provides detailed information on where English is a major language (Wikipedia, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/English_language#Countries_where_English_is_a_major_language, retrieved January 19, 2014)

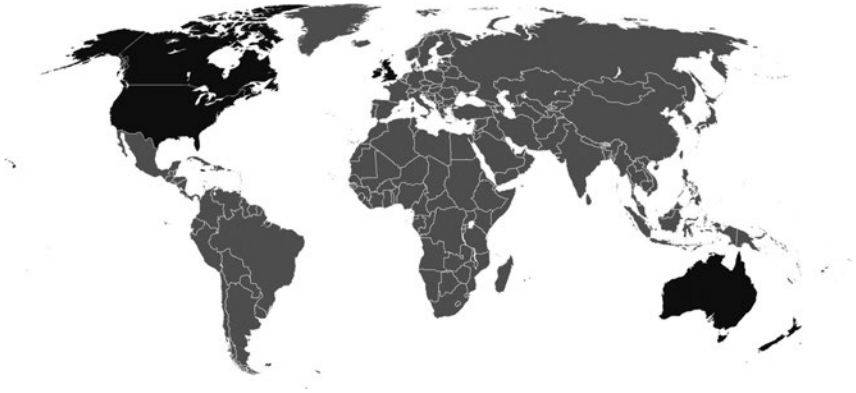


FIGURE 1.1 Countries Where English Is a Major Language

Countries Where English Is a Major Language

In the following countries, English is spoken natively by the majority of the population. English is the primary language in Anguilla, Antigua and Barbuda, Australia, the Bahamas, Barbados, Belize, Bermuda, the British Indian Ocean Territory, the British Virgin Islands, Canada, the Cayman Islands, Dominica, the Falkland Islands, Gibraltar, Grenada, Guam, Guernsey, Guyana, Ireland, the Isle of Man, Jamaica, Jersey, Montserrat, Nauru, New Zealand, Pitcairn Islands, Saint Helena, Ascension and Tristan da Cunha, Saint Kitts and Nevis, Saint Vincent and the Grenadines, Singapore, South Georgia and the South Sandwich Islands, Trinidad and Tobago, the Turks and Caicos Islands, the United Kingdom, and the United States.

In some countries where English is not the most commonly spoken language, it is an official language; these countries include Botswana, Cameroon, the Federated States of Micronesia, Fiji, Gambia, Ghana, Hong Kong, India, Kenya, Kiribati, Lesotho, Liberia, Malta, the Marshall Islands, Mauritius, Namibia, Nigeria, Pakistan, Palau, Papua New Guinea, the Philippines (Philippine English), Rwanda, Saint Lucia, Samoa, Seychelles, Sierra Leone, the Solomon Islands, Sri Lanka, Sudan, South Sudan, Swaziland, Tanzania, Uganda, Zambia, and Zimbabwe. Also there are countries where in a part of the territory English has become a co-official language, e.g., Colombia's San Andrés y Providencia, and Nicaragua's Mosquito Coast. This was a result of the influence of British colonization in the area.

English is one of the 11 official languages that are given equal status in South Africa (South African English). It is also the official language in current dependent territories of Australia (Norfolk Island, Christmas Island, and Cocos Island) and of the United States (American Samoa, Guam, Northern Mariana Islands, Puerto Rico (in Puerto Rico, English is co-official with Spanish), and the U.S. Virgin Islands), and the former British colony of Hong Kong.

Although the United States federal government has no official languages, English has been given official status by 30 of the 50 state governments. Although falling short of official status, English is also an important language in several former colonies and protectorates of the United Kingdom, such as Bahrain, Bangladesh, Brunei, Cyprus, Malaysia, and the United Arab Emirates.

Number of L2 Speakers of English

One might ask why English, and not Mandarin or Spanish, is today considered an international language since they have far more native speakers. The answer to this puzzle rests in the current number of second-language speakers of English. The British Council (www.britishcouncil.org/learning-faq-the-english-language.htm, retrieved January 12, 2014) summarizes the following estimates of the relative numbers of first- and second-language speakers of English.

- English is spoken as a first language by around 375 million and as a second language by around 375 million speakers of the world.
- Around 750 million people are believed to speak English as a foreign language.
- Speakers of English as a second or foreign language outnumber those who speak it as a first language.
- One out of four of the world's population speaks English to some level of competence; demand from the other three-quarters is increasing.

These numbers demonstrate two facts: first, there are far more L2 speakers of English than L1 speakers of English; and second, if we consider the number of L2 speakers of English, the current number of speakers of English—both L1 and L2—far surpasses the number of people who speak Mandarin and Spanish.

Pedagogical Implications

So what does all this mean for the teaching of English? First, it is important to note that even though English has official status in many countries of the world today, this does not mean that everyone in the country speaks English well. For example, in Singapore, Singlish, or colloquial Singaporean English, is a variety of English that developed from the influence of Chinese, Tamil, and Malay on the use of English in the country. Most Singaporeans are familiar with this variety of English and with Standard Singapore English, but there are some Singaporeans, generally older and less educated Singaporeans, who speak only Singlish. Cases such as this demonstrate the need to localize all generalizations regarding current English use. One cannot assume that because English has official status in a country, all citizens of the country speak the language well. This is one value of local teachers of English. They are well aware of the range

of English fluency in the country and of the varieties of English that are spoken in the local area.

Second, these statistics regarding the current use of English make it clear that the number of L2 speakers of English is far greater than the number of L1 speakers. Based on this fact, learners of English have a far greater chance of using English with other L2 English speakers than with L1 speakers. Yet many English textbooks continue to include only dialogues between local learners of English and L1 English speakers. The fact is that many learners of English will need to communicate with other L2 speakers who may have gaps in their knowledge of English. Because of this, breakdowns in communication can be common. This has many implications for the teaching of English, ones which we will fully explore in coming chapters.

Varieties of English: Common Features

The spread of English has affected the varieties of English that are spoken today. Since most speakers of English today are bilingual, they have another language that they use on a daily basis. In many instances, these other languages affect their use of English; often the most obvious influence is on pronunciation. (See Chapter 5 for a discussion of some of these influences.) The development of many new varieties of English has raised complex issues of grammatical standards, a critical issue that we will return to later. (See Chapter 4.) For now, we will illustrate some common features of many of the varieties of English as a way of showing that most of these differences do not impede comprehension.

In a seminal work on varieties of English, Kachru (1989) argued that the different roles that English serves in countries around the world are best conceived of in terms of three concentric circles: (a) the *Inner Circle*, where English is the primary language of the country such as in Australia, Canada, the United States, and the United Kingdom; (b) the *Outer Circle*, where English serves as a second language in a multilingual country such as in Singapore, India, and the Philippines; and (c) the *Expanding Circle*, where English is widely studied as a foreign language, such as in China, Japan, and Korea. Subsequent scholars have convincingly maintained that such a categorization is an oversimplification of a complex situation of language use. For example, in some Outer Circle countries such as India or South Africa, segments of the population have little or no knowledge of English and hence, make no use of English on a daily basis. Nevertheless, in those contexts in which a stable and large bilingual population makes use of English along with one or more languages on a daily basis, there are bound to be changes in all of the languages used due to phonological and grammatical transfer and the borrowing of words. These varieties of English are called *World Englishes*.

Scholars who subscribe to this framework seek not only to document the uniqueness of various varieties of English, but also to argue that such varieties should be seen as legitimate and standard in the local context. They contend that

rather than a monocentric basis of standardization based on Inner Circle native speakers, there should be a recognition of the pluricentric nature of current English use with standards based on the language used and accepted in the local context. There is then an emphasis in discussions of World Englishes on the cultural embeddedness and uniqueness of each variety of English. Nevertheless, many of these varieties share common features. The following list provides examples of some of these shared features.

Pronunciation

Consonants

Jenkins (2003, pp. 23–25) summarizes some of the phonological variations that can be found in World Englishes regarding *consonant* and *vowel* sounds. They include:

1. Replacement of the fricatives [θ] and [ð] by other sounds, usually [d] and [t] on their own or followed by slight friction.

   For example, speakers of Indian and West Indian Englishes will use the sounds [t] and [d] instead of the fricatives [θ] and [ð], so that the words *thin* and *this* are pronounced *tin* and *dis*.

2. A tendency to reduce the aspiration (a small puff of air) after voiceless consonants such as /p/, /t/, and /k/ at the beginning of words so they sound like /b/, /d/ and /g/.

   As a result, the word *pin* sounds like *bin*.

Vowels

1. A tendency to shorten vowel sounds.

   Singaporean, Indian, and African Englishes are among the World Englishes that minimally distinguish (if at all) between the short and long vowels [ɪ] and [i:] as in the words *sit* and *seat*, which are both pronounced as [ɪ].

2. A lack of distinction between long and short vowels.

   Many World Englishes, including Indian, Filipino, Lankan, and Singaporean Englishes, pronounce [a:] without its length. The word *staff* is thus pronounced as *stuff*.

Grammar

Drawing on the work of Platt, Weber, and Ho (1984), McKay and Bokhorst-Heng (2008) note the following grammatical innovations in World Englishes.

Nouns (p. 65)

1. A tendency not to mark nouns for plural.

   Up to twelve year of schooling. (India)
   A province will be divided into district. (Philippines)

2. A tendency to use a specific/non-specific system for nouns rather than a definite/indefinite system, or to use the two systems side by side.

   - Non-specific:

   I really want to spend some time in village, definitely if I get chance. (India)

   - Specific:

   Got one boy, morning also eat instant noodles, afternoon also eat instant noodles, night also eat instant noodles. Suddenly he died. The doctor found a lot of wax in his stomach. (Malaysia)

3. A tendency to change the form of quantifiers.

   Don't eat so much sweets. (Singapore)
   You are expected to say some few words. (Sri Lanka)

4. A tendency to convert certain uncountable nouns to countable (examples cited by Shim, 1999, p. 252, taken from a high school English textbook).

   Although it is a hard work, I enjoy it. (Korea)
   An old man showed a great patience. (Korea)

5. A tendency not to make a distinction between the third person pronouns 'he' and 'she'.

   My mother, he live in kampong. (Malaysia; a 'kampong' is a small village.)
   My husband who was in England, she was then my fiancé. (East Africa)

6. A tendency to change the word order within the noun phrase.

   Ninety over cheques. (Singapore/Malaysia)
   That your brother will he come? (Nigeria)

Verbs (pp. 85–86)

1. A tendency not to mark the verb for third person singular in its present-tense form.

   Instead of 'She drinks milk,' a speaker of Philippine English might say, 'She *drink* milk.'

2. A limited marking of verbs for the past tense.

   I move to hostel. (India)

Last year I stay three months in Germany. (Singapore)
Some of them are crying because teacher ask them to read stories in Filipino. (Philippines)

3. A tendency to use an *aspect* system (completed or ongoing action) rather than a *tense* system (past or future) or to use both systems side by side.

   It was during that time these people make some arrangement with law enforcement agencies. . . (West Africa)
   I still eat. (I am/was eating; Malaysia)

4. A tendency to extend the use of *be + verb + ing* constructions to stative verbs.

   She is knowing her science very well. (East Africa)
   The squad we are having here is good enough to beat Namibia. (South Africa, from Kamwangamalu, 2001, p. 58)

5. The formation of different phrasal and prepositional verb constructions.

   Her name cropped in the conversation. (East Africa)
   You can voice out what you are not satisfied with at the meeting. (Singapore)
   Each and every day one was well informed to cope up with any eventuality. (written English, West Africa)
   The older generation finds it difficult to do with young people. (Korea, from Shim, 1999, p. 251)
   Gardens come on life again. (Korea, from Shim, 1999, p. 251)

Lexical Innovation

Perhaps the most interesting aspect of innovations in Worlds Englishes is the coining of new words. As Platt et al. (1984) argue, "When a new variety of a language develops, it does not develop in isolation but it depends on the communicative needs of those who speak it and write it" (p. 87). For example, political circumstances in post-apartheid South Africa gave rise to the creation of various new lexical terms such as the *rainbow-X* compound (Kamwangamalu, 2001). The term refers to the coming together of groups that were previously segregated under apartheid. The term is often used in compound phrases such as *the rainbow-national school* or *the rainbow swimming pool.* Lexical innovation can also occur through borrowing in which words from other locally spoken languages are incorporated into English. For example, Singapore English has borrowed the Malay word *barang-barang* meaning things, especially personal belongings or any kind of small possessions, roughly equivalent to the English word *stuff.*

Varieties of English: Public Attitudes

Local attitudes toward such variation differ greatly. For some, such innovations are an indication of how speakers of English have made English their own by

incorporating their culture and concerns in the language. This is a process that Kachru (1989) terms *nativization*. For others, however, such innovations equal "bad English" and need to be eradicated. This is evident in a government-sponsored campaign in Singapore, called the Speak Good English Movement (SGEM), which has been trying to do away with Singlish or the localized variety of English in place of Standard Singapore English. Launched in 2000 by then-Prime Minister Goh Chok Tong, the campaign continues today through advertisements, school programs, and community meetings. The following excerpts exemplify the strong opposition toward Singlish by political leaders.

> Singlish is not English. It is English corrupted by Singaporeans and has become a Singapore dialect. . . . Singlish is broken, ungrammatical English, sprinkled with words and phrases from local dialects and Malay which English speakers outside Singapore have difficulties in understanding. . . . Let me emphasize that my message that we must speak standard English is targeted primarily at the younger generation. . . . . We should ensure that the next generation does not speak Singlish.
>
> *(Goh Chok Tong,* The Straits Times, *29 August 1999)*

> We cannot be a first world economy or go global with Singlish. . . . The fact that we use English gives us a big advantage over our competitors. If we carry on using Singlish the logical final outcome is that we too, will develop our own type of pidgin English, spoken only by 3 million Singaporeans which the rest of the world will find quaint but incomprehensible. We are already half way there. Do we want to go all the way?'
>
> *(Goh Chock Tong, National Day Rally Speech, 1999)*

> They [younger Singaporeans] should not take the attitude that Singlish is cool or that speaking Singlish makes them more "Singaporean." They have a responsibility to create a conducive environment for the speaking of good English. . . If they speak Singlish when they can speak good English, they are doing a disservice to Singapore.
>
> *(Goh Chok Tong at the launch of the 2000 SGEM)*

On the other hand, some Singaporeans view the use of Singlish as a sign of the uniqueness of Singaporean culture and celebrate it through literature and pop lyrics. One example of this is the following short excerpt from a poem that appeared on a website called mrbrown.com, which is a pro-Singlish website that publishes material in defense of Singlish trying to counter the government's anti-Singlish stance.

> **Singlish Poem**
>
> . . . But actually we all got one "culture" in Singlish.
> It's like rice on the table; it is our common dish.

I know this funny "culture" is not the best around
so we must tahan a bit until a better one is found.
Not all the time can marry the best man,
so bo pian got no prawns, fish also can.
I donno whether you agree with me or not?
I just simply sharing with you my thoughts.
Singlish is just like the garden weeds.
You pull like mad still it would not quit.
Sure got some people like and some do not like.
Singlish and English, they'll still live side by side.

(Source: www.mrbrown.com/blog/2000/09/singlish_poem.html, retrieved, January 17, 2014)

The poem depicts the role that Singlish plays in the local environment and affirms the belief that both varieties can exist side by side, a belief not shared by all Singaporeans, as demonstrated in the statements of political leaders. The Singlish example demonstrates how variation in English can result in heated public debates—often ones between those in power and those who are younger, less educated, and less wealthy.

Varieties of English: The Question of Standards

As was pointed out earlier, within each country in which a local variety of English is spoken, some speakers are familiar with both the local variety and a more universally accepted variety of English. At the same time, there are speakers, often the less educated and poorer, who are familiar only with the local variety of English. Whereas many would argue that it is the responsibility of English classrooms to familiarize students with a widely accepted variety of English, in some contexts, the teachers themselves are not fully familiar with such a variety of English. This raises extremely complex questions as to what standards are appropriate for some local contexts. To illustrate this situation let us consider the example of Wesbank High described in Blommaert (2010).

Wesbank is one of the first post-apartheid housing projects in the Western Cape. Most of the inhabitants are what was previously termed "coloreds" and speak Afrikaans, while approximately 25% are black and speak Xhosa. The poverty and unemployment rate in the settlement is extremely high. Wesbank, the only secondary school in the area, is dual-medium, meaning that classes are offered in English and Afrikanns. In every grade, a small minority of the classes are English medium, the rest are Afrikaans medium. Very few students in the school have English as their mother tongue. Hence, as Blommaert (2010) points out, teachers in Wesbank face a number of challenges: "large classes with a very heterogeneous population with respect to backgrounds, capacity and levels of achievement; a poor and marginalized community; an under-resourced school in which special educational needs cannot be adequately addressed" (p. 83).

All of the learners have problems with basic literacy. Data gathered from their writing showed that almost all students typically display the following features in their writing:

> (i) erratic use of capitals (not using them where needed, using them where not needed);
> (ii) difficulties with singular and plural markers;
> (iii) difficulties with verb inflections, esp. plural marking and tense marking;
> (iv) problems with the use of definite and indefinite articles (not using them where needed);
> (v) a wide range of spelling problems, mostly a result of phonetic spelling (writing according to pronunciation);
> (vi) a tendency to aestheticize writing, even when struggling with basic writing skills—writing as drawing.
>
> *(Blommaert, 2010, p. 84)*

Such features lead to the production of sentences like the following.

> 1. Because they thought that is a Gun Sound and the boy wasn't back @ home.
> 2. If I loved him, He would marry me . . .
> 3. BECAUSE You can Communicate with Everyone with it.
> 4. You can go to the far lands that they speek other language lets say maybe theyspeek French they may understand english.
> 5. English. Because it's the oFFicial Language in South Africa.
>
> *(Blommaert, 2010, p. 84)*

As Blommaert (2010) points out, these features of writing are not unusual; they are termed "grassroot literacy" and are widespread in Africa and elsewhere in the world where "people are inserted in sub-elite literacy economies and have restricted literacy repertoires, and often assume the shape of a skeleton writing competence in which acoustic images of words are noted in an unstable spelling system" (p. 85). What is significant for our purposes is that the teachers themselves display some of these same features, resulting in their not correcting what many might consider "errors." The reason is that the teachers themselves come from the same community as the learners.

The norms then that are applied in this context are what might be termed peripheral norms rather than a universal or singular norm, a norm which neither the students nor the teachers have access to. And as Blommaert (2010) notes, as a consequence, "doing well in school means doing well by local standards" (p. 93). He goes on to argue that:

> Even though, from one perspective, it amounts to lifting "errors" to the level of norms (and thus "normalizing" errors in writing), another

> perspective suggests that it offers interesting pedagogical opportunities and is thus a productive, positive procedure. It can be seen as the *localization* of education standards—something which probably occurs everywhere (we have seen that all over the world English is learned *with an accent*), but is rarely recognized and acknowledged.
>
> *(p. 95)*

While the localized standards may provide a productive learning environment for learners in a difficult social environment, "the localization of norms also involves a move away from the norms of the 'centre.' And these norms, as we know, are hegemonic in the end" (Blommaert, 2010, p. 96). Ultimately, "some skills offer a very low degree of mobility while others offer a considerably larger degree of mobility and transferability across social and spatial domains. 'Standard' literacy usually falls in the second category, while 'non-standard' literacy falls in the first category, even if from one perspective it can be seen as 'full', developed, complex literacy within a restricted repertoire of literacy skills and resources" (p. 100). The point is that English today is "a multiplex item composed of at least two different objects: *English1* an ideologically conceived homogenous and idealized notion of 'English-the-language-of-success, and *English2*, a situationally and locally organized pragmatics of using 'English' in ways rather distant from English" (p. 100).

Pedagogical Implications

Our discussion of current varieties of English has clear ramifications for teaching and assessment. The discussion demonstrates that in many English-speaking contexts, students will bring to the classroom varieties of English that serve important purposes in their community in establishing a sense of community and rapport with other local speakers. Teachers need to be aware of these varieties and the functions they serve in the local community. In some cases, teachers will want to add to the students' English repertoire other varieties of English, ones that often have a greater range of acceptability. In other instances, however, due to students' limited access to education and mobility, it may be more important to work on developing students' general education and knowledge, rather than to focus on developing a far-removed standard of English. Such decisions can only be made by local teachers and administrators who are well aware of the students' goals and needs.

Current Trends in English Education

English Learning in Asian Contexts

English learning today can occur in a great variety of contexts: public and private, primary and secondary schools, tertiary education, private language

institutes, and online learning. The majority of learners, however, are enrolled in public education contexts, since in many countries today, English is a required foreign language. Unfortunately, there are no precise figures on the number of countries in which English is a required foreign language. While the British Council maintains that in the majority of countries today English is a required foreign language, they recommend contacting the ministry of education of a country to determine whether or not English is required. They estimate that in the year 2000, over one billion people were learning English, and they point out that, at any one time, there are over 130,000 students learning English and other skills through the medium of English in British Council learning centers located around the world (www.britishcouncil.org/learning-faq-the-english-language.htm, retrieved, January 12, 2014).

In this section, we have decided to focus on English learning in three Asian countries—China, Korea, and Japan—in both public and private contexts. We have chosen to focus on these countries for three reasons. First, these countries represent a vast number of English language learners, as we shall see below. Second, many of the trends that are occurring in these countries illustrate tendencies in English learning and teaching that are occurring around the globe. And finally, there is more information and research on these countries than on many other countries.

China

Let us begin with China. Beginning in the late 1970s, English language education was high on the government's agenda for modernization. This push resulted in a universal provision for English education in secondary schools, leading to almost 80 million secondary students learning English (Hu, 2002). This number increased in 2001 when the government introduced a compulsory provision for primary English education, requiring that English education begin in Primary 3 from the fall of 2001 in cities and county seats. The implementation of this policy resulted in at least 50 million primary students receiving at least four periods of English instruction per week (Hu, 2002). The growth of English education is also occurring in higher education. In 2001, the Ministry of Education (MOE) mandated that within three years, 5–10% of the courses offered in tertiary education were to be offered in English (Hu, 2002).

In addition to the rapid expansion of English education in public schools, Chinese private language institutes are growing. Presently, in order to meet the growing demands of parents for English classes for their children, private kindergartens that offer English and bilingual classes are developing. There has also been an increase in private English education directed toward older and adult learners, helping them pass high-stake exams. This private market is clearly a lucrative one.

> According to Jiang (2003) the largest private language school in China—the New Oriental School in Beijing—had an annual income of 25 million

> US dollars in 2001. Today, the business of the private English teaching sector is just as brisk, if not more so, as a decade ago. An estimate based on the National Educational Development Statistical Bulletin and published in *China Daily* (N. He 2010) puts the market value of English training in China at a staggering 3.3 billion US dollars.
>
> *(Hu & McKay, 2012, p. 347)*

In addition to the growth of English education in China in the public and private sector, there have been a number of reforms aimed at improving the quality of English education. This includes increasing the required contact hours in public schools for English education and implementing curriculum standards at both the national and local level. There has also been a move to use English to teach content subjects, resulting in what are termed Chinese-English bilingual education programs in the primary and secondary schools. Finally, there has been the top-down promotion of Communicative Language Teaching (CLT) in the public schools (Hu & McKay, 2012).

What is causing this tremendous growth in English education in China? One cause is the belief by many in China that knowledge of English will result in better economic and educational opportunities for themselves and their children. And in fact, English language skills are a key requirement for promotions in government, education, scientific research, and business (Hu & McKay, 2012). Another reason is the formal endorsement of the MOE for English learning. Many MOE documents include specific statements regarding the importance of English education for China's modernization and participation in global cultural, economic and political activities. For example, in 2001 the MOE stated:

> In the modern world of today, scientific progress, represented by developments in information technology, advances by leaps and bounds. The informatization of social life and the globalization of economic activities have made foreign languages, English in particular, an increasingly important tool to facilitate China's opening up and interaction with other countries.
>
> *(Hu & McKay, 2012, p. 348)*

In addition, the MOE endorses the learning of English for cultural and intellectual development in its curriculum standards. For example, in 2003, the MOE in its English curriculum standards for general senior secondary schools stated:

> English is a major subject on the senior secondary curriculum. Learning English can facilitate the intellectual, emotional, attitudinal, and ethical development of senior secondary students and enhance their all-round cultivation. Furthermore, competence in an international language creates favorable conditions for learning the advanced culture, science and

> technology of other countries and for engaging in international interaction. Thus, English language education contributes to raising the quality of Chinese citizenry, facilitating China's opening up, fostering China's international communication, and strengthening China's comprehensive competitiveness.
>
> *(Hu & McKay, 2012, p. 349)*

China's widespread endorsement of English learning is also evident in South Korea.

South Korea

Like China, South Korea has lowered the age for required English learning so that as of 2011 English education begins in third grade. Like China, they have also increased the number of contact hours for English learning. Furthermore, the Ministry of Education, Science and Technology (MEST) is promoting a Teaching English through English (TETE) policy which establishes English as the main language of communication between teachers and learners. Although there is support among teachers for this policy, a variety of surveys demonstrate that the majority of teachers feel anxious about implementing such a policy in their classrooms (Hu & McKay, 2012).

Perhaps the most controversial and growing area of English learning in South Korea has been the establishment of private tutoring options for young South Koreans. In 2006, South Korean parents spent over 20 trillion won or about 20 billion U.S. dollars on private tutoring for their children. These tutoring options include cram schools (*hagwon*), private tutoring (*kwaoe*), English camps (*yeongeocamp*), and language training abroad (*haewoeyonsu*). Currently, three out of every four Korean children goes to a *hagwon*. In fact, the tutoring business is so profitable that some of the successful *hagwon* chains are listed on the Korean stock exchange (Ripley, 2013).

South Korea is one of the few countries that has what are termed "English villages," where students participate in an English-speaking environment, typically staffed by native speakers. In this simulated environment, there is everything from English-speaking post offices to English-speaking doctors' offices. Students take on a Western identity and stay in the village for an extended period of time using only English. Some of these English villages are supported by local governments and participation in them is part of the public school curriculum.

South Korea is also unique in the number of young learners who study in an English-speaking environment for an extended period of time. "According to a report by the MOE and Human Resources Development, in 2006, more than 35,000 elementary and secondary students went to study abroad for a full academic year, half of them being elementary students. Even more went abroad

for short-term language training in English-speaking countries" (Hu & McKay, 2012, p. 350).

Like China, South Korea has also endorsed a communicative language teaching (CLT) approach in English teaching and, in keeping with the emphasis on oral skills in this approach, has included an oral component in their college entrance test. And like China, South Korea in its official documents, supports the promotion of English as a public necessity in order to participate in a global economy.

Japan

In terms of English learning, Japan differs from China and South Korea in several ways. First, English as a compulsory subject in elementary schools did not begin in Japan until 2011, considerably later than in either China or South Korea. However, exactly how to implement the primary education program has been a cause of concern and frustration. Several surveys of elementary English teachers report that teachers are concerned about their own level of English proficiency and are not confident as to what types of activities to use in their classes, so that, in general, English elementary education in Japan has not been highly successful.

> Many elementary schools attempt to organize English experience activities utilizing a "comprehensive learning hour" implemented in 2002, but they are not systematized for raising the English ability over a span of years. In this way, though a plan to make English compulsory in elementary schools is discussed here and there, and some public elementary schools in the "Special Zones for Structural Reform" have started offering regular English classes, profiting from decentralization and flexible curriculum reform, English education in public elementary schools appears to be 'getting off to a bad start' in Japan as a whole.
>
> *(Mikio, 2008, p. 392)*

A second way in which Japan differs from China and South Korea is the lack of a large private tutoring industry. While Japanese parents do support English learning for their children, especially in reference to college entrance exams, they do not send their children for private tutoring to the extent seen in China and South Korea. However, like China and South Korea, public officials and documents support the learning of English in order for Japan to participate in global trade and internationalization. For example, the Ministry of Education, Culture, Science and Technology (MEXT) in one of its official documents on establishing an action plan to teach English states:

> English has played a central role as the common international language in linking people who have different mother tongues. For children living in

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